



Teaming up: (L-R) Hillier, Animesh, Owens and Manikanta at the office of *The Hindu* post their conversation with *Sportstar*. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

thought I'll turn up without training next time," he joked.

Animesh, too, had struggled during the Continental Tour event in his home state, pulling out of the 100m heats to focus on the 200m, after being under the weather following his European sojourn.

The relentless set of engagements this year, however, is partly of his own making. The World University Games in Bochum, Germany, had been earmarked as the marquee event for him this year. **But a NR of 20.40s at the Federation Cup in Kochi in April suddenly opened the doors to the Asian Championships, which in turn ate into his training time.**

Animesh ran 20.45s at the UAE

Athletics Grand Prix in Dubai and followed it up with 20.55s at the Indian Grand Prix in Trivandrum. At the Asian Championships in Gumi, South Korea, he broke his own NR in 200m with 20.32s in the final, bagging bronze. With each passing event, he gathered ranking points, making the Worlds in Tokyo a serious possibility.

"He's earned his right to be competing at this level [Worlds]," said James Hillier, Athletics Director, Reliance Foundation. "He's been developing very well and this hasn't happened overnight. He should view the Worlds as just another event and shouldn't view the athletes as better than him." Despite his achievements, Animesh has had to endure a fair share of setbacks this year. The Asian Championships ended in a damp squib for the 4x100m relay team after it was disqualified in the heats following a botched baton exchange.

"We had the relay medal in our

hands and let it go. *Hum bas Gumi ghoomke aagaye bas* (We just went around Gumi and returned)," Manikanta joked.

Despite the amusement in hindsight, Hillier said the episode had a negative impact on the athletes, who were hoping to win their first continental medal. **He was also miffed at the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) after Animesh and Gurindervir weren't chosen to run in the heats.**

"It was tough on all of us. We put together a winning team that had good chemistry, but ultimately some decisions were taken which were beyond our control. I felt for these guys because this was an opportunity to get a medal," he said.

"Manikanta and Gurindervir had qualified for the individual 100m, but they weren't allowed to participate either. The selection policy wasn't followed, and this plays with athletes' minds. Manikanta really struggled in